



Comparative
Study of English
Versions of

英譯本比較研究
《詩經》

*The Book of
Songs*

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At first, when we set out,
The **willows** were fresh and green;
Now, when we shall be returning,
The **snow** will be falling in clouds.

--James Legge

昔我往矣

楊柳依依

今我来思

雨雪霏霏

——
采薇



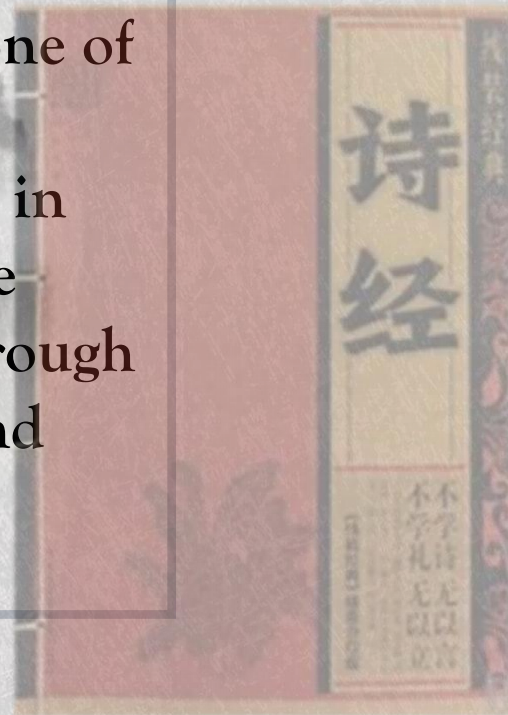
壹

Preface

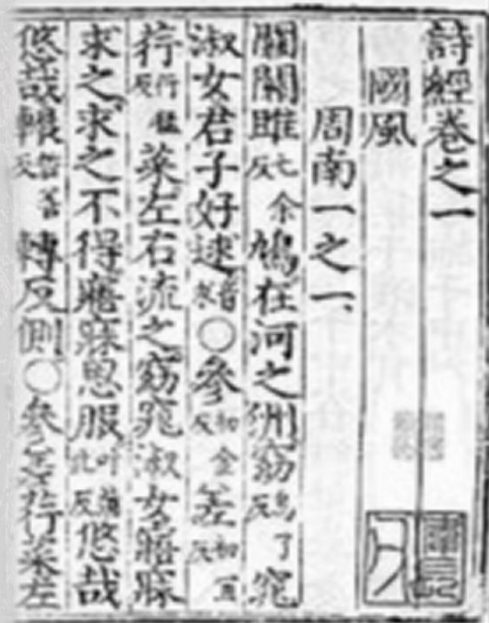


Preface

The Book of Songs is the origin of Chinese poetry and other genres of literature. As one of the Confucian classics and textbooks, this anthology occupies an important position in Confucianism. The English versions of the anthology have opened a wide window through which the westerners could understand and appreciate Chinese culture.



Preface



The English translation of The Book of Songs started in the **mid 18 century**. Later there have appeared many complete and selected English translations of the anthology.

This time we will focus on two of the most distinctive translations. **James Legge's** unrhymed version, which first published in 1871 and **Xu Yuanchong's** rhymed version of 1994.



貳

Introduction and Poetic Features



Introduction

- the **earliest poetry anthology** in China
- consists of **305** poems
- a span between the 11 and the 6 century BC
- the Yellow River region in north and central China
- four sections: **Feng, Xiaoya, Daya and Song**
- musical qualities for the ease of singing
- the **repetition** of certain phrases, lines or even the whole stanza 重章叠咏



Poetic Features

四言体为主的句式

The four-character main
sentence pattern



赋比兴

Fu Bi Xing



重章叠句

the repetition of certain
phrases, lines or even the
whole stanza



音韵美

rhythmic beauty





叁

Comparison of the two translations



James Legge

James Legge (1814-1897), an English missionary and scholar, was the **first** to fully translate the Book of Songs.

Legge put great emphasis on fidelity to the original text. His translation is more **literal** (直译). In translation, he strictly **followed the order of words and sentences** in the original text. He adds **detailed explanations and commentaries**, so the translation is longer.

His academic level of translation is very high, which helps the Western world to increase the understanding of Chinese civilization and culture.



Xu Yuanchong



The English translation of the Book of Songs by Xu Yuanchong (1921-2021), published in 1994, is a good practice of his theory of **"three beauties"** 三美论:

beauty of meaning 意美

beauty of sound 音美

beauty of form 形美

He believes that the most important thing in translation is to preserve the beauty of the original as much as possible. Xu Therefore, in the translation of the Book of Songs, in order to maintain this beauty, he used rhyme all the way. On the basis of accurately grasp the original poem, he fully consider the rhyme characteristics of the original poem, and took **free translation** as the main translation (意译为主) .

Comparison

采薇（节选）
昔我往矣，杨柳依依。
今我来思，雨雪霏霏。



And no one knows our sadness.
At first, when we set out,
The willows were fresh and green;
Now, when we shall be returning,
The snow will be falling in clouds.

When I left **here**,
Willows shed **tear**.
I come back **now**,
Snow bends the **bough**.

Comparison



关雎

关关雎鸠，在河之洲。
窈窕淑女，君子好逑！
参差荇菜，左右流之。
窈窕淑女，寤寐求之。
求之不得，寤寐思服。
悠哉悠哉，辗转反侧。
参差荇菜，左右采之。
窈窕淑女，琴瑟友之。
参差荇菜，左右芼之。
窈窕淑女，钟鼓乐之。

Kwan-kwan go the **ospreys**,

On the islet in the river.

The **modest, retiring, virtuous, young** lady:

For our **prince** a good mate she.

Here long, there short, is the **duckweed**,

To the left, to the right, borne about by the current.

The modest, retiring, virtuous, young lady:

Waking and sleeping, he sought her.

He sought her and found her not,

And waking and sleeping he thought about her.

Long he thought; **oh! long and anxiously**;

On his side, on his back, he turned, and back again.

.....

Comparison



关雎

关关雎鸠，在河之洲。
窈窕淑女，君子好逑！
参差荇菜，左右流之。
窈窕淑女，寤寐求之。
求之不得，寤寐思服。
悠哉悠哉，辗转反侧。
参差荇菜，左右采之。
窈窕淑女，琴瑟友之。
参差荇菜，左右芼之。
窈窕淑女，钟鼓乐之。

By riverside are **cooing**
A pair of turtledoves;
A good young man is **wooing**
A fair maiden he loves.

Water flows left and right
Of **cresses** here and there;
The youth yearns day and night
For the good maiden fair.

His yearning grows so strong,
He cannot fall asleep;
He tosses all night long,
So deep in love, so deep!

.....

Comparison

蒹葭

蒹葭苍苍，白露为霜。

所谓伊人，在水一方。

溯洄从之，道阻且长。

溯游从之，宛在水中央。

蒹葭萋萋，白露未晞。

所谓伊人，在水之湄。

溯洄从之，道阻且跻。

溯游从之，宛在水中坻。

蒹葭采采，白露未已。

所谓伊人，在水之涣。

溯洄从之，道阻且右。

溯游从之，宛在水中沚。

传统
文化

The reeds and rushes are deeply green,
And the white dew is turned into hoarfrost.

The man of whom I think
Is somewhere about the water.
I go up the stream in quest of him,
But the way is difficult and long.
I go down the stream in quest of him,
And lo! he is right in the midst of the water.

.....

Comparison

蒹葭

蒹葭苍苍，白露为霜。

所谓伊人，在水一方。

溯洄从之，道阻且长。

溯游从之，宛在水中央。

蒹葭萋萋，白露未晞。

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溯游从之，宛在水中坻。

蒹葭采采，白露未已。

所谓伊人，在水之涣。

溯洄从之，道阻且右。

溯游从之，宛在水中沚。

传统
文化

The reeds grow green;
Frosted dew-drops gleam.
Where can she be seen?
Beyond the stream.
Upstream I go;
The way's so long.
And downstream, lo!
She's thereamong.

.....



肆

Ezra Pound



Ezra Pound

庞德对于诗经的翻译有独特的见解，他在 1929 年首次提出“三诗”说，认为有三种给语言充注能量的方法，即声诗（melopoeia）、形诗（phanopoeia）和理诗（logopoeia）。该理论不仅是一种诗学理论，也是一种翻译思想。庞德认为，形诗几乎完全可译，声诗只在机缘巧合时可译，而理诗微妙复杂，很难做到完全翻译。

而实际上，庞德在《诗经》翻译过程中花费了大量时间研究音韵。据考证，庞德早在 1945 年到 1946 年初就完成了《诗经》英译初稿，而译本直到 1954 年才出版面世。在这期间，庞德反复查阅词典，并在汉学家方志彤的帮助下，写下了 9 本注音笔记。可见，庞德虽然声称“声诗不可译”，却没有对《诗经》中的声诗掉以轻心，而是努力领会，并尽力在译本中予以重现。庞德面对《诗经》中“不可译”的声诗，表现出一种“知其不可而为之”的翻译态度。这一态度集中体现在庞德为了重现《诗经》声诗所使用的各种创造性翻译方法上，包括反常规的音译、大量拟声词，以及歌谣体的使用。

1. 反常规音译

音译 (transliteration) 即依声托事，是翻译中常用的方法。其常规使用范围包括专名翻译、民族特有事物翻译、无对应词的词语翻译和特殊情况下某些名词的翻译。然而庞德在一些反常规的地方使用了音译：

Eg: 绵绵葛藟，在河之浒。（《王风·葛藟》）
Vine over vine along the Ho,
thru the vine-clad wilderness I go (36)

君子万年，福禄宜之。（《小雅·鸳鸯》）
“Kün tsy wan nien”

May his happiness flow in harmony with earth and with heaven.



翠柳，一行
上青天。
秋雪，
门泊东吴
万里船。

更初，
嘉瑞天教
及岁除。
未举，
灯前小草
写桃符。

2. 多样化拟声词

声诗翻译的另一手段是使用多样化的拟声词。拟声词是摹仿人或自然界的聲音而形成的特殊词汇，往往出现在口语化作品中，而《诗经》中拟声词格外丰富。与之相应，庞德在译文中也使用了大量仿造或自创的拟声表达，比如以下几例：

坎坎伐檀兮，置之河之干兮。（《魏风·伐檀》）
K' an, k' an, sandalwood / planks are good by Ho

伐木丁丁，鸟鸣嚶嚶。（《小雅·伐木》）
“Takk! Takk!” axes smack / Birds sing “ying, ying”



3. 歌谣体的使用

歌谣体也是声诗翻译的一种创造性手段，庞德以之翻译《诗经》中的叠咏体。所谓叠（迭）咏体，是指诗中各章句数相同，且对应诗句具有相同的句式，某些短语或诗句重复出现。

庞德为了再现这种重章复沓的特色，使用了与之相近的歌谣体。

桃之夭夭，灼灼其华。……桃之夭夭，有蕢其实。
（《周南·桃夭》）

O omen tree, that art so frail and young, / so glossy
fair to shine with flaming flower;

O omen peach, that art so frail and young, / giving us
promise of such solid fruit,



庞德会通过拆解汉字，从汉字部首中提取意象。这也是他的“表意文字法”（ideogrammic method）在翻译中的体现。表意文字法是庞德受汉字表意性启发提出的一套诗学和翻译方法，在翻译中主要表现为对汉字偏旁部首的拆解。

例如，他把“日出有曜”中的“曜”字译为“feathers of light”，就是从“曜”字中拆解出“羽”“日”两个部首。

这种“拆字法”还可细分为三种：其一，抽取单个部首创造意象；其二，在多个部首间构建联系，创造意象；其三，在部首和汉字本义间构建联系，创造意象。

思无邪，思马斯徂。（《鲁颂·駉》）

So our lord's thought bite / and his cavalry charges.



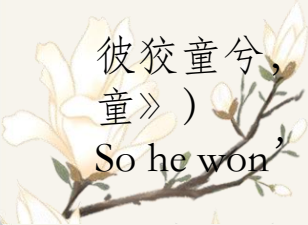
理诗

logopoeia

释义法

三诗中，理诗最为微妙复杂。庞德将理诗比作“词语之间的智慧之舞”，后来又总结为利用词语与其“用法”（usage）的特殊关系实现赋义。现在我们可以把理诗理解为巧妙利用词语的各种联想意义，表达复杂的思想和态度。

庞德否定理诗的可译性，认为只能通过释义传达它所表达的思想态度。实际上，在《诗经》翻译中，庞德对理诗翻译表现出“有所为有所不为”。也就是说，对于这类特殊表达，庞德有时采用释义法，有时则省略其中的深意。



彼狡童兮，不与我言兮。/维子之故，使我不能餐兮。（《郑风·狡童》）

So he won't talk to me when we meet? / Terrible! / I still can eat.



伍

Conclusion



桃之夭夭 灼灼其華

青青子衿 悠悠我心

巧笑倩兮 美目盼兮

瞻望弗及 泣涕如雨

山有扶蘇 隰有荷華

投我以木瓜 報之以瓊琚

執子之手 與子偕老

A decorative frame with a light gray background and a white border. The frame is adorned with stylized clouds at the top and bottom corners and bamboo branches on the left and right sides. The text "谢谢观看" is centered within the frame.

谢谢
观看